

# 10 Most Common Medical MISTAKES

## that doctors in India make and what needs to be done

By Damayanti Datta

It took two long months for a Delhi hospital to throw in the towel. It took just two short days for Jayant K. Bhuyan, 58-year-old senior executive of the Confederation of Indian Industries, to lose his life on the operation table. Just because someone inadvertently put in a wrong tube of oxygen into his brain. Stunning as it was, it wasn't a one-off. Just a few months back, the apex court hauled up a Hyderabad hospital for a surgery that left a man paralysed; in Chennai, a woman went in for tubectomy and lost her bladder; in Kolkata, a man died during chemotherapy after being injected in the spine instead of the vein; in Mumbai, a baby declared dead was found alive at the time of burial; the Delhi High Court brought to book a private hospital for the death of a boy due to "accidental" laser sparks from a machine; the apex court declared that patient's consent is essential as a woman's uterus was removed without her consent in Delhi.

Physician, heal thyself? The good news is, the medical fraternity is sitting up and taking note. "Mistake, mishap, mischief, call it what you may, the sacred covenant of trust inherent in the doctor-patient relationship is starting to crumble," says Dr C.P. Kamle, a hospital planning and management expert based in Hyderabad. Ever since the Supreme Court brought the patient-doctor relationship under the ambit of the Consumer Protection Act in 1995, the number of complaints against doctors has gone up. But in the absence of information, no one really knows how many such cases occur. Also, the law does not clarify the difference between "gross negligence", "error of judgement", "accident" and "recklessness". Of the 110 cases that came to the Delhi Medical Association between January 2007 and April 2008, negligence was proved in just 34. The 10 most common lapses that doctors across the country believe the medical fraternity needs to guard against and what needs to be done:

Illustrations by SAURABH SINGH

